Week 1 - Introduction & Housekeeping

Dino Wildi

15 October 2026

About Me

- Dr. Dino Noah Wildi (please call me Dino)
- Postdoctoral researcher since June 2025
- Research interests: party strategy, climate politics, radical right, computational social science
- Personal interests: Games, floorball, ice hockey

Your turn

- Who are you?
- What do you study?
- What do you already know about quantitative methods?
- What interests you about QTA?
- One personal interest or hobby

IPW Social Media

There is an IPW Social Media for info (deadlines, job postings, events...)

Instagram

LinkedIn

Communication and Materials

- My classes are on first name basis
- Email: dino.wildi@ipw.uni-heidelberg.de (DE or EN)
- Emails are read at least once every 24 hours
- Office hours: by appointment via email
- Materials are available online:
  - Readings and slides: Moodle
  - Code and slides: GitHub

Expectations

- Class is interactive $\Rightarrow$ Attendance is in your interest
- Excused absences (e.g. doctor's note): via mail
- It is assumed you have done the readings
- Questions via mail or in class
- If you have a question, others probably have it too!
  - Ask them in public (via email if you're shy)
  - Ask your classmates to help you!

Assessments

- Composite grade from 3 assessments:
  - Presentation: 75%
  - Discussant feedback: +/- 0.3 on presentation grade
  - Average of lab assignments: 25%
- Term paper as sole basis for written assessment
- 2+6 ECTS: aggregated by uni standards

Asessment registration

You have to sign up for your assessment of choice
This is separate from course registration!

Deadline for signing up: **01.11.2026**

Asessment registration

You have to sign up for your assessment of choice
This is separate from course registration!

Deadline for signing up: **01.11.2026**

You have to decide between **large** and **small assessment**:

- Changes possible 17.01. - 31.01.2027
- No registration possible past deadline
- No changes possible past deadline

Presentation

Task: Create and present research design

- Know the different steps in a QTA workflow
- Link methods to research questions
- Think about potential issues (validity, text availability, ...)

Presentation

Task: Create and present research design

- Know the different steps in a QTA workflow
- Link methods to research questions
- Think about potential issues (validity, text availability, ...)
- Get feedback in advance for your term paper
- Gain academic presentation skills

Presentation logistics

- Individual presentations
- Length: 10 minutes
- Date: last X weeks
- Slides: **Monday 23:59** to me + discussant
  - Minor changes can still be made
- No prior meeting needed, but recommended

Discussion

Task: Provide feedback for one colleague

- Engage with a research design other than your own
- Practice giving feedback in a conference-like setting
- Help each other improving your work

Discussion

Task: Provide feedback for one colleague

- Engage with a research design other than your own
- Practice giving feedback in a conference-like setting
- Help each other improving your work
- 2-3 min after your colleague's presentation
- No slides or materials required
- "A strength, a weakness, an idea, a question"

Lab Assignments

Goal: Get familiar with R

- Weekly practice tasks based on current topic
- Starts in class, chance for questions
- Finish at home and send by **Wednesday 23:59**
- Submission as HTML in RMarkdown via email
- You can help each other but have to results individually

Lab Assignments: Grading

- Main expectation is that you complete the assignment
- Complete, functional, clean code = 3 points
- Mostly functional code with some issues = 2 points
- Complete code with major issues = 1 point
- Incomplete / no submission = 0 points
- Points summed up for final grade

Term Paper

- 2500 words excluding footnotes, references, appendices
- Must use at least one QTA method
- Free choice of topic & specific method
- Submit both a paper and a code package
- Deadline: **31.03.2027 at 23:59**

Tools

R, RStudio, RMarkdown

- Should have installed **R & RStudio** by now
- Use of R and related tools is **required** for the class
- References: package manuals, R for Data Science

Tools

R, RStudio, RMarkdown

- Should have installed **R & RStudio** by now
- Use of R and related tools is **required** for the class
- References: package manuals, R for Data Science

GitHub

- **Option** to work with GitHub Desktop
- Access to code, solutions, and slides
- References: GitHub Documentation (docs.github.com)

LLM use

- Open your favourite LLM platform
- Enter: "Write me R code that calculates the mean horsepower and MPG per engine category and cylinder number in the mtcars dataset."

LLM use

- Open your favourite LLM platform
- Enter: "Write me R code that calculates the mean horsepower and MPG per engine category and cylinder number in the mtcars dataset."
- Do you understand what you are looking at?
- Can you fix the problem if you find one?

LLM use

- ChatGPT, Claude, Vibe, etc all solve this well...
- ... BUT they assume things that may not be true:

LLM use

- ChatGPT, Claude, Vibe, etc all solve this well...
- ... BUT they assume things that may not be true:
  - Names of datasets and variables
  - Structure/contents of your data
  - Tools (e.g. Base R vs tidyverse)
  - Downstream tasks

$\Rightarrow$ It is okay to use LLMs *if you can assess & fix the output*

Better LLM use

- Download or copy *example_mtcars.R* from GitHub
- Put it into your LLM of choice and prompt it to explain the code line by line
- Prompt the model to adapt the code to also calculate average quarter mile time (qsec)

Better LLM use

- Download or copy *example_mtcars.R* from GitHub
- Put it into your LLM of choice and prompt it to explain the code line by line
- Prompt the model to adapt the code to also calculate average quarter mile time (qsec)

You can use LLMs as a learning tool or to adapt something that you already understand (or both)